

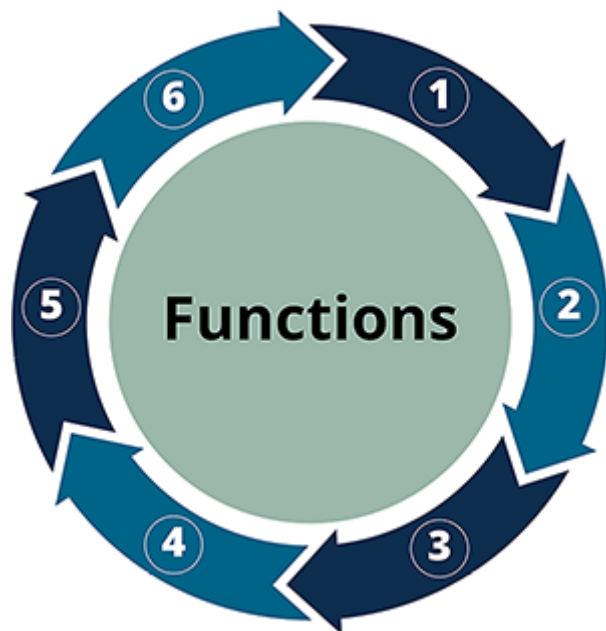
Veterinary leadership and technical expertise for Australia's animal health system

The Animal Health Committee (AHC) delivers strategic policy, technical, and regulatory advice and national leadership on animal health and biosecurity matters. It is responsible for delivering on national priority reform areas and overseeing the development and implementation of animal health strategies and standards. AHC is a sectoral committee of the National Biosecurity Committee (NBC).

AHC's principal objective is to maintain or improve animal health outcomes and manage animal biosecurity risks.

AHC also facilitates trade through national leadership, strategic direction and collaboration with stakeholders.

AHC's six key functions:



- Develop science-based and nationally consistent policy on animal health issues relevant and important to Australia.
- Provide advice on animal health to NBC, the veterinary and animal health community, and the public.
- Provide leadership in developing and implementing veterinary policy on animal health issues (including welfare).
- Facilitate cooperation and collaboration across agencies and between industry and government.
- Provide expert advice on animal health to inform government policy and priorities.
- Implement nationally coordinated activities to strengthen animal health and biosecurity systems.

Australia enjoys a high level of food quality and a strong reputation for animal health among agricultural trading partners. AHC's efforts in surveillance, monitoring, and reporting systems help

substantiate claims of freedom from certain animal diseases, ensuring that Australia can detect, diagnose, and control animal diseases effectively.

For information on current outbreaks in Australia please visit outbreak.gov.au.

Membership

Committee members include the chief veterinary officers (CVOs) of the Commonwealth, states and territories, along with representatives from CSIRO's Australian Centre for Disease Preparedness (ACDP) and the Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (DAFF).

Observers include representatives from Animal Health Australia, Wildlife Health Australia, and the New Zealand Ministry for Primary Industries. Observers are invited by the AHC Chair to participate at committee meetings in an advisory or consultative capacity, and do not have voting rights.

Member and observer websites can be found on the [Resources](#) page.

Committee members

- Kyeelee Driver, ACT CVO
- Debbie Eagles, Director ACDP
- Beth Cookson, Australian CVO (ACVO)
- Louise Palfreyman, Commonwealth
- Jo Coombe, NSW CVO
- Sue Fitzpatrick, NT A/CVO
- Allison Crook, QLD CVO
- Skye Fruean, SA CVO
- Kevin De Witte, TAS CVO
- Graeme Cooke, VIC CVO
- Michelle Rodan, WA CVO

Meeting arrangements

AHC meets face-to-face twice each year in a different state or territory each time. AHC members also meet regularly by videoconference to discuss issues of national importance and consider matters out of session.

The AHC co-chairs consist of a permanent chair – the ACVO – and a rotating co-chair. The co-chair position rotates annually among jurisdictional representatives, ensuring a diverse leadership. AHC Secretariat support is provided by DAFF.

Stakeholder sessions

AHC regularly engages with national terrestrial and aquatic industry members and veterinary services to ensure a collaborative approach to national animal health. As part of this engagement AHC holds two

combined stakeholder sessions each year that are integrated into the face-to-face meetings as well as several sector specific sessions. These sessions provide an opportunity for animal health stakeholders to meet directly with AHC members to build strong relationships and ensure collective understanding of the strategic priorities for the national animal health system.

Sub-committees of AHC

AHC is supported by the:

- [Sub-committee on Aquatic Animal Health](#)
- [Sub-committee on Animal Health Laboratory Standards](#)
- [Sub-committee on Emergency Animal Disease](#)

Newsletter

AHC publishes the [AHC Communique](#) with information on topics considered at face-to-face meetings. A new communique is developed after each face-to-face meeting.

Contact us

To contact the AHC Secretariat please email ahc@aff.gov.au.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/health/committees/ahc>